

PUJOL



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SEPTEMBER 5TH, 2024



PUJOL

MENÚ DEGUSTACIÓN

BOTANAS

Tostada of avocado and dehydrated egg yolk
Vuelve a la vida of tomatoes from Toluca, onion and chiles
Baby corn with coffee mayonnaise and *chicatanas* ants powder

CRUDO DE ATÚN ALETA AZUL

Bluefin tuna fish crudo, avocado slices, coriander seeds, *pico de gallo* with capers
heart of peach palm juice with herbal oil, *quelites* Mexican herb
Served with sweet potato chips with chile powder

TOSTADA DE KAMPACHI

Tostada with Baja California kampachi, *serrano* mayonnaise prepared in the style of *chile toreado*
leek, grasshopper, and topped with *serrano* pepper slices

PESCADO DE ROCA

Grilled red snapper from Oaxaca, *mole verde de pistache* with pistachio, vinegar, spinach, tomatillo, and Chile
cucumber and shallot, fava beans, watercress, and toasted pistachios

BARBACOA

Lamb slow cooked for eight hours, rain season mushrooms, lamb jus with bone reduction, corn husk ash
Guacamole with *aceite de totomoxtle* corn husk ash oil
Tamal style eggplant cooked in plantain leaf, *salsa borracha* made with *chile de arbol*
salsa verde cruda, and *tortillas* to make a taco

MOLE MADRE 3499 DÍAS Y MOLE NUEVO

Old mother mole sauce aged for 3499 days, based on black *chile chilhuacle*, chocolate, and nuts
New mole sauce made with seasonal fruits and red *chile chilhuacle*
Served with purple corn *tortillas* and *hoja santa*

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ATAULFO

Sorbet of mango and sake, mango mousse, elderflower, fermented lime granita,
marshmallow of Szechuan pepper, green oil of basil and *chile serrano*

MIGNARDIS

Conchita with Tonka bean cream
Chocolate with *pixtle*



When people talk about Mexican gastronomy, two names inevitably come up: Pujol and Quintonil. While Quintonil represents a rising star of the new guard, Pujol remains the timeless classic, owned and led by chef Enrique Olvera. Rooted deeply in traditional Mexican cuisine, Pujol showcases dishes centered on maize, seafood, and tacos, presented through either a refined tasting menu or an omakase-style taco bar.

Founded in 2000, Pujol began with a menu that leaned into Asian and American influences, incorporating only faint traces of Mexican tradition. After facing financial headwinds, the restaurant made a decisive shift by returning to its culinary roots and embracing the richness of traditional Mexican culture. Long before the Michelin Guide arrived in Mexico, Pujol had already gained global acclaim through The World's 50 Best Restaurants. Ranked #20 in 2017, it ascended to an impressive #5 by 2022. However, the two years that followed saw a sharp decline, with the restaurant slipping to 13, then 33. One can't help but wonder what changed. Still, with Michelin's long-awaited debut in Mexico, Pujol received two stars, a renewed endorsement that compelled me to experience for myself what the restaurant now has to offer.

Pujol offers two menu options: a more traditional tasting menu served at the table, and a more daring taco omakase bar. Since it is my first visit, I opt for the traditional menu, hoping for a comprehensive introduction to the restaurant's identity. I even consult photos and the restaurant's floor plan ahead of time to select what I think will be the perfect seat. But upon arrival, a series of issues immediately surface. First, despite it being midday, the restaurant has fully drawn its blackout shades, plunging the interior into near darkness. The seat I chose based on natural lighting turns out to be the darkest corner of the room. For someone who enjoys photographing their meal, or simply experiencing their food in a well-lit environment, it is frustratingly dim, bordering on inhospitable.

Worse still, the table setup is deeply flawed. The seats and tables are both fixed in place, and as a shorter Asian man, I find the spacing incredibly cramped. The distance between the seat and the table leaves me almost wedged in, and the narrow tabletop barely offers enough room to rest my elbows comfortably. For a restaurant with international acclaim, such an ergonomically flawed design is frankly baffling. I honestly can't imagine how a tall guest from Europe or the U.S. would navigate this seating arrangement. When I raise the issue, the staff offer no satisfactory solution.



Then there is the music. In the background, the restaurant plays John Coltrane's classic American jazz. While beautiful in its own right, it feels strangely out of place in a restaurant so dedicated to celebrating Mexican culinary heritage. I have to ask, is American jazz really the right soundtrack for a restaurant that claims to embody the spirit of Mexico?

After a moment of struggle to find some degree of comfort and finally settling into my seat, the first course arrives: a trio of botanas, or snacks in English. Each small bite offers a distinct interpretation rooted in traditional Mexican flavors, reimagined through a contemporary lens.



The first is a tostada of avocado and dehydrated egg yolk. In Mexican cuisine, tostada broadly refers to any dish built on a toasted or crispy tortilla base. Here, the chef takes a modern approach, creating a tostada sandwich with creamy avocado and topping the tostada with delicate shavings of cured egg yolk. The flavor profile, however, is bold, tangy, salty, and intense, making it a challenging first bite.

Next comes a vegetarian version of *vuelve a la vida*, made with tomatoes from Toluca, onions, and chiles. *Vuelve a la vida*, literally meaning "return to life," is traditionally a bracing seafood cocktail believed to revitalize the body and soul. In this rendition, seafood is replaced by bright, juicy tomatoes, paying tribute to the produce of Toluca. It's far lighter and more refreshing than the first dish, and its sweet acidity works beautifully to cleanse the palate, serving as a more fitting introduction to the meal.



The third snack is the most captivating, featuring baby corn brushed with coffee mayonnaise and dusted with chichatana ant powder. The young corn, already delicious with its grassy sweetness and tender bite that almost resembles a baby bamboo shoot, is elevated by the addition of a rich, aromatic coffee mayonnaise. It adds depth without overpowering the delicate corn. The final flourish, chichatana ant powder, is nothing short of inspired: nutty, smoky, and umami-rich, it infuses the dish with an earthy, primal complexity that feels distinctly and unapologetically Mexican.



As the *dégustation* journey officially unfolds, the first course showcasing raw bluefin tuna arrives on the table. At the center sit slices of avocado topped with quelites, a variety of Mexican herbs, beneath which the crudo of bluefin tuna is subtly hidden, awaiting the exploration from the diner. Coriander seeds and an unconventional pico de gallo featuring capers are used to elevate the flavor profile. The entire composition is then gently bathed in a broth made from peach palm juice and then sublimated by a drop of herbal oil. On the side, sweet potato chips dusted with chile powder add an extra layer of texture and spice as I enjoy the course. The peach palm base brings a light yet soothing touch, offering a creamy, almost milky texture and a flavor reminiscent of artichoke or young bamboo. The pairing of avocado and tuna may be classic, but classic doesn't mean boring. Here, the dish shines through its balance and harmony, delivering a satisfying opening act rich in contrast and cohesion.



Now, the excitement arrives in the form of a kampachi tostada. Sourced from Baja California, the thinly sliced kampachi is layered into a delicate flat dome and topped with slivers of serrano pepper. The heat is echoed beneath the fish, where a serrano mayonnaise prepared in the style of chile toreado adds depth. Chiles toreados are blistered or fried chiles, often jalapeños or serranos, commonly served as a side in Mexican cuisine. The true revelation, however, lies hidden underneath: a layer of grasshoppers paired with sautéed leek. The grasshoppers are exceptional, earthy, umami-rich, with a flavor reminiscent of mushrooms, soy sauce, and preserved vegetables. Their deep savoriness grounds the dish and forms a brilliant counterpoint to the clean, oceanic umami of the kampachi. It's a bold yet balanced bite, unexpected and unforgettable.



Pujol's menu isn't particularly long, and I now find myself entering the main course section. The first dish, a grilled red snapper from Oaxaca, paired with a mole verde de pistache — a vibrant green mole made with pistachios, vinegar, spinach, tomatillo, and chile. Alongside it comes a garnish of cucumber and shallot, fava beans, watercress, and toasted pistachios. At first glance, it's unclear whether the dish is meant to celebrate the mole verde de pistache or the red snapper. The mole takes center stage on the plate, while the modestly portioned snapper is arranged around it. And yet, the mole clearly exists to complement the fish, its role is supposed to be supportive, not dominant. My interpretation is that the dish serves as a platform to highlight the inventive reinterpretation of mole, one that pays homage to tradition while daring to chart new territory. The red snapper, then, is the vehicle through which this bold new mole gets to shine. And shine it does. The mole verde de pistache is delicious, the pistachio flavor comes through brightly and beautifully, and the supporting elements are skillfully integrated. As for the surrounding vegetables, I have a feeling that they're not meant to be experienced individually, but rather as a collective accompaniment, adding textural contrasts and layered complexity to the dish as a whole.



Following the fish course comes a true feast: lamb barbacoa. In Mexico, barbacoa, or asado en barbacoa, refers to an indigenous cooking method that involves slow-roasting meat in a pit or earth oven. It's not only a technique that ensures even, gentle heat but also a ritualistic nod to Mother Earth. In this iteration, I'm presented with a medallion cut of lamb loin, slow-cooked for eight hours until meltingly tender. It's accompanied by a chunk of rainy-season mushrooms, enriched with a lamb jus reduced with bone, and accented by a dusting of corn husk ash. The entire composition leans into a monochromatic deep tone, earthy and dramatic in both flavor and appearance. On the side, a small portion of guacamole is served, topped with aceite de totomoxtle, aka corn husk ash oil, which adds a subtle smokiness and a faint echo of corn. But this is far more than just a meat course, it's a full barbacoa experience. Alongside the lamb is a tamal-style eggplant, slow-cooked in a plantain leaf and topped with chickpeas, carrying prominent smoky tone. It comes with two salsas: salsa borracha, an alcohol-infused sauce made with chile de árbol, and salsa verde cruda, a bright, fresh green salsa. Fresh tortillas are brought out from the kitchen, warm and pliable, inviting me to wrap everything together into a taco.



The lamb itself is exquisitely tender, and pairing it with mushrooms is a classic move, safe but deeply satisfying. The corn husk ash adds a subtle, earthy smokiness with a whisper of toasted corn, rounding out the flavors beautifully. The eggplant, too, is tender and rich, its texture nearly collapsing into the salsas. Wrapped in a tortilla, the various components may be soft and yielding, but the tortilla's chewiness adds just enough structural contrast to avoid monotony. Whether savored element by element or folded into a taco, this course is deeply enjoyable, comforting, layered, and full of soul. Both Quintonil and Pujol present a barbacoa feast as the centerpiece of their tasting menus. I had always associated tacos with casual street fare — something found at food trucks or roadside stands. But now, I've come to understand just how deeply embedded they are in the culinary identity of Mexico. A taco can be both humble and elevated, a vehicle for comfort and a canvas for celebration, at once everyday and extraordinary.



What follows is the true centerpiece of the degustation journey, undeniably Pujol's most iconic dish, and the reason many make the pilgrimage here. I doubt there is another restaurant in the world bold enough to place a sauce at the climax of a tasting menu, not to mention after fish and lamb courses. This dish is Mole Madre y Mole Nuevo: the legendary mother mole and its newly made counterpart. Today, the aged mole is exactly 3,499 days old. Every day, its flavor subtly evolves. Reheated, replenished, frozen, and revived in a near-sacred cycle. Over 9.5 years, it has grown deeper, more layered, more enigmatic. It is a flavor that defies ingredients or technique, this is the taste of time, of history, of cultural memory. The Mole Madre is built upon black chile chilhuacle, chocolate, and nuts. Its counterpart, the Mole Nuevo, is made with seasonal fruit and red chilhuacle. Unlike traditional moles that often rely on a blend of four chili varieties, these two are crafted with just one: the rare and regional chilhuacle. Pujol doesn't fry the chiles, but roasts them, to avoid excess oil. The sauces are spiced with digestives, and made without the use of meat-based broths, stripping the mole back to its essence, yet allowing it to speak with clarity and depth. Served with freshly made purple corn tortillas and a single leaf of hoja santa, the dish is both austere and profound. The Mole Nuevo is spirited — spicy, sweet, with a brightness reminiscent of beans and fruit. The Mole Madre, by contrast, is dark, bitter, chocolatey, and deeply herbal, almost like Chinese medicine in its complexity. One evokes the present; the other, the past. One is immediate; the other, eternal. And it is the hoja santa that ties them together, cutting through with its fresh yet peppery-smoky, anise-like clarity, a breath of green to balance the gravity of age.



Since I was quite uncomfortable with the indoor seating, the restaurant kindly offered to move the dessert course outdoors for me. This outdoor area is usually reserved for large parties during the dessert service. A server leads me through a small back path, I find myself in a modest garden where I can catch a glimpse of the hoja santa plant featured in the previous course, growing lush and vibrant. Moments later, I arrive at the serene outdoor space and is seated at a large circular black stone table, its center adorned with a cluster of succulents. The setting is not only more comfortable, but also imbued with a quiet beauty that marked a gentle shift in the meal's rhythm, preparing me for the final chapter.

The menu is rather concise, and there's only a single dessert course. No palate cleanser, no interlude. The spotlight here is on mango. The dish features a quenelle of mango and sake sorbet, paired with a cloud of mango mousse adorned with elderflower and a dusting of fermented lime granita. Hidden underneath are delicate cubes of Szechuan pepper marshmallow, all resting in a shallow pool of green basil oil infused with chile serrano. This dessert is a refined finale, an elegant fusion of cultures. It speaks with a French patisserie's precision and finesse, yet its soul remains unmistakably Mexican. The inclusion of sake nods to Japan, while the subtle numbing tingle of Szechuan pepper and the green heat of serrano oil reflect Mexico's deep-rooted affection for spice. These spicy elements are used with restraint, adding just a whisper of heat that enhances the fruit's brightness without overpowering it, making the dish exciting yet approachable for a global audience. The final two bites are more conventional in form: a conchita choux filled with tonka bean cream, and two pieces of chocolate infused with pixtle (Mamey seed). While these mignardise draw on native Mexican ingredients, both their flavor and technique continue to express a distinctly French voice, bringing the journey to a refined coda.







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